

Checklist:

Staffing Checklist

One-line principle

- ☐ Hire competent people of character, onboard them deeply, coach them continuously, promote them thoughtfully, and act quickly when performance or behavior threatens the team.

Staffing Checklist

1. Define the hiring standard

- ☐ Hire for **competence and character**
- ☐ Avoid over-indexing on vague “cultural fit.”
- ☐ Look for people who think differently from the current team
- ☐ Reject brilliant-but-toxic candidates
- ☐ Value integrity, intent, humility, and trustworthiness
- ☐ Remember that strong teams are built from **competent people of character**

2. Own staffing as a manager responsibility

- ☐ Treat staffing as one of the manager’s most important jobs
- ☐ Do not outsource ownership of staffing to HR
- ☐ Personally drive recruiting, interviewing, hiring, onboarding, development, and promotion
- ☐ Treat staffing as a continuous responsibility, not a one-time hiring event

3. Recruit actively

- ☐ Build a network of candidates before openings exist
- ☐ Recruit continuously through referrals, events, meetups, conferences, partners, and personal outreach

- ☐ Look for talent inside the company, not just outside
- ☐ Use recruiting as a way to improve diversity of thought and background
- ☐ Invest time in long-term candidate relationships
- ☐ Make recruiting a standing priority

4. Avoid staffing anti-patterns

- ☐ Do not equate staffing with just filling reqs
- ☐ Do not rely passively on HR sourcing
- ☐ Do not optimize for pedigree, prestige, or brand-name employers
- ☐ Do not overvalue domain experience at the expense of product ability
- ☐ Do not confuse individual star power with team effectiveness
- ☐ Do not outsource core product work that should remain a core competency

5. Prepare the interview process

- ☐ Curate the interview team carefully
- ☐ Choose interviewers based on both competence and character
- ☐ Ensure each interviewer knows exactly what they are evaluating
- ☐ Keep the hiring bar high for product managers, designers, and tech leads
- ☐ Distinguish clearly between hiring for current competence and hiring for potential
- ☐ Make sure unresolved questions get answered before the process ends

6. Evaluate candidates well

- ☐ Assess demonstrated competence
- ☐ Assess character, integrity, and trustworthiness
- ☐ Look for coachability and self-awareness
- ☐ Value diversity of perspective and experience
- ☐ Avoid using “cultural fit” as a catch-all rejection filter
- ☐ Be careful not to overvalue domain knowledge
- ☐ Watch for toxic behavior hidden behind strong credentials

7. Close strong candidates quickly

- ☐ Move quickly once you identify a strong candidate
- ☐ Try to make an offer within 24–48 hours
- ☐ Conduct reference checks personally
- ☐ Ask references whether they would hire the person again

- ☐ Look for signs of disrespectful or toxic behavior
- ☐ Personally communicate your commitment to coaching and development

8. Set the right management span

- ☐ Keep the span of control realistic for coaching-heavy roles
- ☐ Reduce the span when employees are inexperienced
- ☐ Reduce the span when managers are inexperienced
- ☐ Account for operational load and organizational complexity
- ☐ Make sure managers have enough time to coach well

9. Support remote employees deliberately

- ☐ Protect discovery collaboration between PM, design, and tech
- ☐ Avoid replacing collaboration with waterfall-style artifacts
- ☐ Use prototypes as the primary discovery artifact
- ☐ Handle sensitive issues over video rather than chat
- ☐ Explicitly build and maintain trust
- ☐ Be flexible about people's time constraints and working situations

10. Onboard intentionally

- ☐ Treat the first 90 days as critical
- ☐ Check in at key milestones:
 - ☐ End of first day
 - ☐ End of first week
 - ☐ After the first paycheck
 - ☐ After the first month
 - ☐ After the first 60 days
- ☐ Establish trust early
- ☐ Assess strengths and gaps
- ☐ Create a coaching plan
- ☐ Build relationships with team, leaders, and stakeholders
- ☐ Expose the new hire to customers, business context, and key functions
- ☐ Monitor stakeholder feedback over the first several months

11. Run a strong new employee bootcamp

- ☐ Go beyond generic orientation
- ☐ Ensure new product people quickly learn:

- ☐ How decisions are made
- ☐ What matters most to the company now
- ☐ How trust is built in the organization
- ☐ What are the most important priorities
- ☐ Consider a structured first-week bootcamp
- ☐ Include personal growth, communication, and self-awareness work
- ☐ Teach strategic context, not just process
- ☐ Cover core company-specific topics such as:
 - ☐ Customer understanding
 - ☐ Company history and context
 - ☐ Vision
 - ☐ Financial model
 - ☐ Customer discovery
 - ☐ Validation
 - ☐ Prioritization
 - ☐ Measurement
 - ☐ Go-to-market
- ☐ Bring in experienced product people to share real stories and context
- ☐ Include practical workshops where new hires apply what they learned
- ☐ Create a safe space to practice with their future teammates
- ☐ Reinforce that the goal is not to tell smart people what to do, but to equip them to solve problems well

12. Use performance reviews correctly

- ☐ Treat annual reviews as compliance/admin, not your main feedback mechanism
- ☐ Use weekly 1:1s as the primary feedback tool
- ☐ Make sure there are no performance surprises in annual reviews
- ☐ Give honest, timely, constructive feedback throughout the year
- ☐ Do not avoid hard feedback because of discomfort or conflict aversion
- ☐ Make performance expectations unmistakably clear
- ☐ Hold managers accountable if they fail to surface issues early
- ☐ Remember that the primary purpose of the 1:1 is for the employee

13. Address performance problems responsibly

- ☐ Recognize that avoiding termination starts with better recruiting, hiring, onboarding, and coaching
- ☐ Balance compassion with responsibility and prompt action

- ☐ Consider the impact of poor performance on:
 - ☐ The team
 - ☐ The product organization
 - ☐ Stakeholders
 - ☐ Company culture
- ☐ Work with HR on compliance, but own the judgment and leadership
- ☐ Distinguish between:
 - ☐ A hiring mistake/competence issue
 - ☐ A toxic behavior issue
- ☐ For competence problems:
 - ☐ Provide clear coaching
 - ☐ Share concerns with increasing clarity and urgency
 - ☐ Give a reasonable period to improve
 - ☐ Help the person find a better-fitting role when appropriate
- ☐ For toxic behavior problems:
 - ☐ Protect the team's trust and psychological safety
 - ☐ Determine whether the issue is temporary or chronic
 - ☐ Do not let strong skills excuse damaging behavior
 - ☐ Act decisively if the behavior persists

14. Promote people deliberately

- ☐ Treat promotion as a major responsibility of management
- ☐ Understand each employee's career aspirations
- ☐ Discuss both individual contributor and leadership paths
- ☐ Assess current skills against the next role's requirements
- ☐ Identify gaps clearly
- ☐ Create a plan for learning and demonstrating those skills
- ☐ Use employee self-assessment alongside manager assessment
- ☐ Help people get ready before openings appear
- ☐ Advocate strongly once someone is genuinely ready
- ☐ Be explicit that promotions may require broader approval and timing
- ☐ Be especially careful when promoting an IC into management, since it is a different job, not just a senior version of the same one

15. Retain strong people

- ☐ Remember that people often leave managers, not companies
- ☐ Watch for regrettable attrition as a signal of management problems

- ☐ Run exit interviews, especially for strong people you did not want to lose
- ☐ Look for patterns in why strong people leave
- ☐ Build a reputation as a manager who coaches and develops people
- ☐ Recognize that great managers often attract internal transfers because people want to work for them

16. Develop future talent

- ☐ Identify high-potential people early
- ☐ Consider an APM or similar development program
- ☐ Only run such a program if you have leaders capable of serious coaching
- ☐ Admit only genuinely high-potential candidates
- ☐ Create individualized development plans
- ☐ Use structured coaching over 1-2 years
- ☐ Use talent development to strengthen long-term bench strength and diversity

Manager operating rhythm checklist

Weekly

- ☐ Spend real time recruiting
- ☐ Run high-quality 1:1s
- ☐ Give direct feedback
- ☐ Check the progress of newer hires
- ☐ Watch for trust, morale, and team health issues

Monthly

- ☐ Review your recruiting pipeline
- ☐ Review top performers' development and promotion readiness
- ☐ Review struggling employees and coaching plans
- ☐ Check retention risks
- ☐ Reassess whether your org structure and span of control support coaching

Quarterly

- ☐ Review whether the team is getting stronger
- ☐ Evaluate whether onboarding is working
- ☐ Revisit succession and talent-development plans

- ☐ Identify any toxic behaviors or performance issues being tolerated too long
- ☐ Audit whether managers are actually giving timely feedback